

Workshop: Designing an AI Mental Health Support App

Introduction

Thank you for participating in this session!

We are a group of students at **TH Köln** working on a **Requirements Engineering** project. Our goal is to design an AI-assisted mental health support application that helps university students manage stress, burnout, exam anxiety, and other everyday mental health challenges.

This session consists of **two parts**:

- Part 1 - Interview:** Understanding your experiences, challenges, and current coping strategies.
- Part 2 - Workshop:** Collaboratively generating ideas and prioritizing features for an ideal AI mental health application.

There are **no right or wrong answers**. We are interested in your honest thoughts and experiences. The entire session will take approximately **45-60 minutes**. Your participation is voluntary, and your responses will be used **only for academic purposes**.

Part 1 - Qualitative Interview

Objective

The purpose of the interview is to better understand students' experiences with academic stress, current coping strategies, and expectations regarding AI-supported mental health services.

Interview Questions

Academic Stress

- When do you usually experience the most stress during the semester?
- What are the main reasons for your stress?
- How does academic stress affect your daily life?

Coping Strategies

- How do you usually cope with stress?
- Which coping strategies work well for you?
- Are there any strategies that you have tried but found unhelpful?

Existing Solutions

- Have you ever used a mental health or well-being application?
- If yes, what did you like or dislike about it?
- Have you ever used AI (e.g., ChatGPT) for emotional support or advice?

Expectations

- What kind of support would you like to receive during stressful periods?
- What concerns would you have about using an AI mental health application?

Part 2 - Collaborative Workshop

Brainstorming

Before generating ideas, let's briefly look at some existing mental health applications and discuss their features.

Existing Applications

Wysa

- AI chatbot for emotional support
- Daily mood check-ins
- CBT-based coping exercises
- Guided breathing and mindfulness activities

Example:

After telling the chatbot that you feel anxious about exams, it suggests a breathing exercise and guides you through managing anxious thoughts.

Youser

- Mood journal
- Emotion tracking
- AI-guided self-reflection
- Personalized mental health insights

Example:

The app identifies that your stress levels increase every Tuesday and recommends establishing a weekly relaxation routine.

Headspace

- Guided meditation
- Sleep support
- Focus exercises
- Stress reduction programs

Example:

Students can choose a "10-minute meditation before exams" to reduce anxiety.

Repika

- AI companion chatbot
- Daily conversations
- Habit tracking
- Emotional support

Example:

The chatbot remembers previous conversations and follows up on events you mentioned earlier.

Discussion

After reviewing these examples:

- Which features do you find the most useful?
- Which features would you never use?
- What features are missing from these applications?
- If you could combine the best features into one app for students, what would it include?

Brainstorming Paradox

Now let's think about the opposite.

- What should **never** happen in a mental health app?
- What would make you stop using it?
- What concerns would you have when using such an application?

After identifying these issues, we will discuss how they could be prevented.

Feature Prioritization

Finally, please select the **three most important features** for an AI-supported mental health application.

Possible features:

- AI Chatbot
- Daily Mood Check-ins
- Mood Tracking
- Personalized Coping Strategies
- Stress Monitoring
- Guided Mindfulness Exercises
- Emergency Support Information
- Contact to University Counselors
- Anonymous Usage
- Customizable Notifications
- Exam Stress Support
- Personalized Progress Reports

Closing

Thank you very much for your participation.

Your insights will help us better understand students' needs and translate them into functional and non-functional requirements for our Requirements Engineering project.

Existing Mental Health Applications

Before generating your ideas, we will briefly look at some existing mental health applications. The purpose is not to evaluate these apps, but to explore discussion about features that students find useful or unnecessary.

Wysa

Main Features

- AI assistant for emotional support
- Guided breathing and mindfulness exercises
- Mood tracking
- Self-help tools based on CBT techniques

Youser

Main Features

- AI companion chatbot
- Mood journaling
- Emotion tracking
- Personalized mental health insights

Headspace

Main Features

- Guided meditation
- Sleep support
- Stress reduction exercises
- Focus and mindfulness programs

Repika

Main Features

- AI companion chatbot
- Daily conversations
- Emotional support
- Habit and mood check-ins

Discussion

After reviewing these examples, let's discuss your opinions.

Q1

Which features do you find the most useful?

Q2

Are there any features you would never use?

Q3

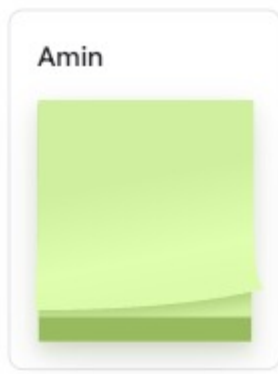
What features do you think are missing from these existing applications?

Q4

If you could combine the best features into one app for university students, what would it include?

Q5

Is there any feature you wish existed but have never seen in a mental health app?

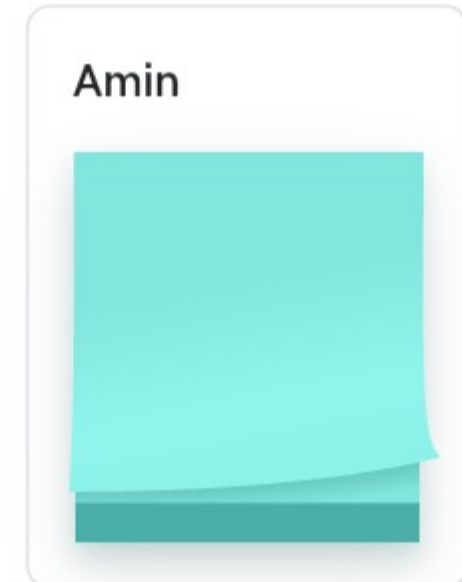


Brainstorming

Some guiding questions:

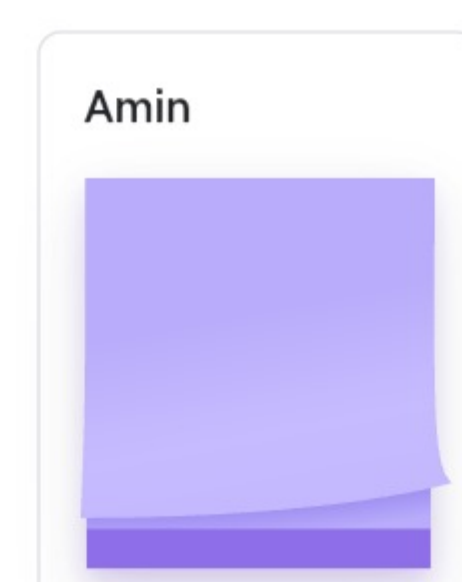
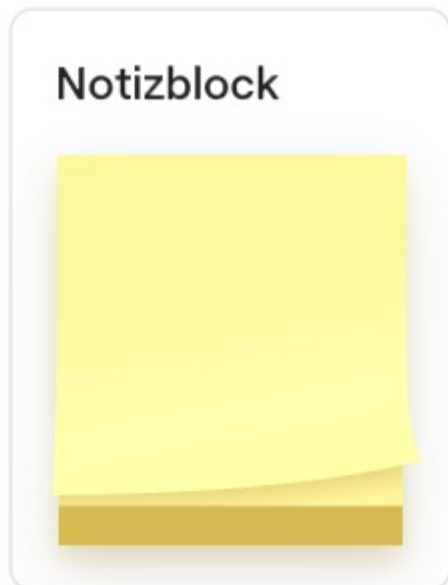
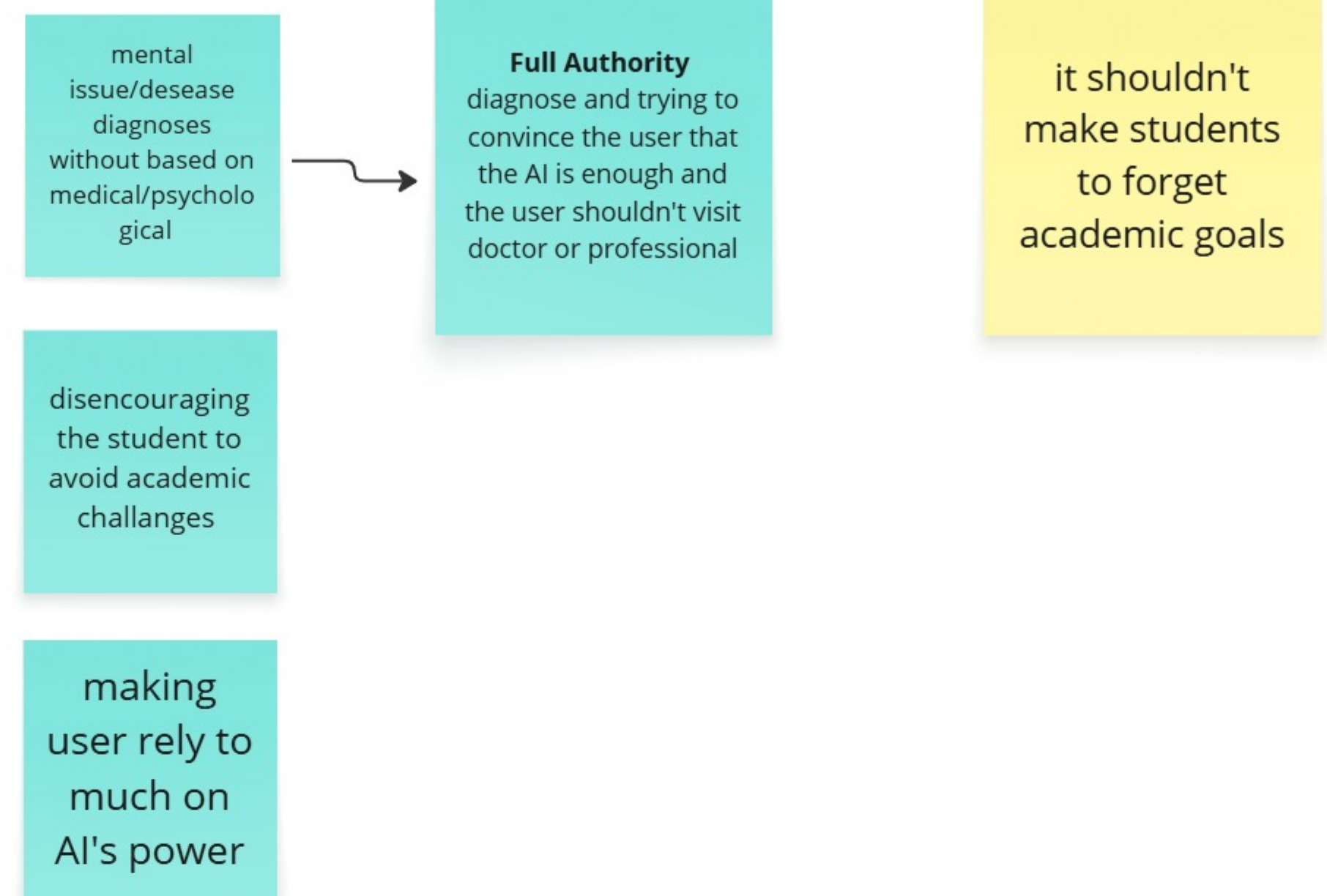
- What features should the app have?
- What would make you use it regularly?
- How could AI best support students?
- What would make the app helpful or enjoyable?

Analyze user's mental health not through chats in the beginning, but by providing one therapy /consulting session with the real therapist at the beginning. And then the ai personalizes it with these data.



Brainstorming Paradox

- What should **never** happen in a mental health app?
- What would make you stop using it?
- What concerns would you have?



Prioritization

